58 Eli

The aging priest of Shiloh who trained Samuel but would not restrain his own sons.

Eli was the priest at Shiloh, where the ark of God stood in the last days of the judges, and he judged Israel forty years. He blessed a weeping Hannah, raised her son Samuel, and taught the boy to answer God's call. But his own sons, Hophni and Phinehas, were corrupt priests who treated the LORD's offerings with contempt, and Eli only scolded them. God warned him twice that judgment would fall on his house. In one day the ark was captured, both sons were killed, and Eli fell and died. His life shows both humble faith and the cost of failing to act.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Eli*, possibly meaning "high" or "lifted up"
Office	Priest at Shiloh; judged Israel forty years (1 Samuel 1:9; 4:18)
Family	Sons Hophni and Phinehas; grandson Ichabod (1 Samuel 1:3; 4:21)
When	End of the judges, in Samuel's childhood; no firm date
Key places	Shiloh, Ebenezer and Aphek
Key people	Hannah, Samuel, Hophni and Phinehas, a man of God
Age at death	Ninety-eight (1 Samuel 4:15)
New Testament	Not named

"And Samuel told him every whit, and hid nothing from him. And he said, It is the LORD: let him do what seemeth him good."

1 Samuel 3:18, KJV

The life of Eli

Scripture gives no calendar dates for Eli. He died at 98 after judging Israel forty years. Samuel was born c. 1100 BC (a rough date), and Eli died some years later, while Samuel was still young.

At Shiloh

Blesses Hannah

Eli sits by a post of the temple of the LORD. He mistakes Hannah's silent prayer for drunkenness, then hears her story and blesses her: "the God of Israel grant thee thy petition." *1 Samuel 1:9–18*

Some years later

Receives Samuel

Hannah brings her weaned son to Shiloh and gives him to the LORD. The child ministers to the LORD before Eli, and each year Eli blesses Elkanah and Hannah when they come up to sacrifice. *1 Samuel 1:24–2:11, 19–21*

Very old

Rebukes his sons

Eli hears of his sons' greed with the sacrifices and their sin with the women who served at the tabernacle door. He warns them that no one can plead for a man who sins against the LORD, but they will not listen. *1 Samuel 2:12–17, 22–25*

A warning

The man of God

A prophet tells Eli that he honors his sons above God. Both sons will die on one day, and God will raise up a faithful priest who will do all that is in God's heart. *1 Samuel 2:27–36*

One night

Samuel's call

When the LORD calls Samuel three times, Eli perceives that it is God. He tells the boy to answer, "Speak, LORD; for thy servant heareth." In the morning he accepts God's word of judgment. *1 Samuel 3:1–18*

Age 98

Dies at the news

Israel loses to the Philistines, the ark is taken, and Hophni and Phinehas are killed. When Eli hears that the ark is taken, he falls backward from his seat, breaks his neck and dies. *1 Samuel 4:1–18*

Key activities

Scripture does not state Eli's ancestry. Many trace it to Aaron's son Ithamar, because a later priest in his line is counted among Ithamar's sons (1 Chronicles 24:3). The judgment on his house was fulfilled when Solomon removed Abiathar (1 Kings 2:27).

1. **Served at Shiloh.** He sat at the temple of the LORD as priest and judged Israel forty years. *1 Samuel 1:9; 4:18*
2. **Misjudged, then blessed.** He first thought Hannah was drunk, but he listened and sent her away in peace. *1 Samuel 1:12–17*
3. **Raised Samuel.** The boy ministered to the LORD under Eli's care. *1 Samuel 2:11, 18; 3:1*
4. **Rebuked too little.** He asked his sons, "Why do ye such things?" but did not stop them. *1 Samuel 2:23–25; 3:13*
5. **Honored his sons above God.** The man of God charged him with making himself fat on the best of Israel's offerings. *1 Samuel 2:29*
6. **Taught Samuel to listen.** He helped the boy recognize God's voice and respond. *1 Samuel 3:8–10*
7. **Accepted God's judgment.** He insisted that Samuel tell him everything, then said, "It is the LORD." *1 Samuel 3:17–18*
8. **Trembled for the ark.** He waited by the wayside, "for his heart trembled for the ark of God." *1 Samuel 4:13*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Eli.

Old Testament

1 Samuel 1–4	This is the main account.
1 Samuel 14:3	Eli's great-grandson Ahiah serves as priest in Saul's day.
1 Kings 2:27	Solomon removes Abiathar, fulfilling "the word of the LORD, which he spake concerning the house of Eli in Shiloh."
Psalm 78:60–64	and **Jeremiah 7:12–14.** God forsook the tabernacle at Shiloh, and "their priests fell by the sword."

New Testament

Echoes	"Whom the Lord loveth he chasteneth" (Hebrews 12:6). A church leader must be one who rules his own house well (1 Timothy 3:4–5).

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Eli tell Samuel to say when the LORD called again (1 Samuel 3:9)?
2. *Understand:* Eli spoke to his sons but "restrained them not" (1 Samuel 3:13). What is the difference between rebuking and restraining?
3. *Apply:* Eli helped a young person learn to hear God. Whom could you encourage in faith this month?
4. *Apply:* Is there a wrong you have put up with because confronting it feels hard? What is one step you could take?